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Communication & Career Program

MODULE 1 · THE PERSONAL STACK

Friday, June 5, 2026 · 10–11 AM PST



A good conversation isn't a "nice to have." It's how you build the connection that gets you remembered — in the internship, in the interview, on the call that lands the job.

Without it, you get short answers, awkward silences, and a forgettable impression. **With it**, people open up, enjoy talking to you, and remember your name.

Reflect

- Why does building a real connection matter when you're trying to get hired?

- Think of someone you found easy to talk to — what made it easy?

- When a conversation has stalled for you, what usually went wrong?

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Module 1: The Personal Stack



Building Rapport with the Personal Stack

Module 1

Rapport is built by getting genuinely curious about people and asking better questions. The **Personal Stack** is a set of six pictures that means you always know what to ask next — so any conversation can move from small talk to real connection.

Module Objectives Checklist

- ✓ Always know the next question to ask
- ✓ Move a conversation from small talk to real connection
- ✓ Ask open-ended questions that get stories, not one-word answers

These skills are the foundation everything else in the program is built on.



Creating a Trusted Connection

When you meet someone new, you often know little about them — and a trusted connection early shapes the whole conversation. People relax when they discover shared interests, and connecting authentically (not just swapping facts) makes it matter for both sides.

That's where the Personal Stack comes in. Six pictures, in order, each standing for an easy topic. We remember pictures, not words — so picture each one on your own home and you'll always know what to ask next.

Picture Prompt	Question Ideas for Easy Connection
	Nameplate — “Hi, my name’s _____. What’s yours?” Give your name, get theirs, and get on first-name terms early.
	House — Where are you from? Where do you live? How long have you lived there? <i>What do you like about it?</i>
	Family portrait — Tell me about your family. Any family living close by? <i>(Keep it open — let them choose what to share.)</i>
	Golf club — What do you do for fun? What did you do last weekend? <i>What have you got planned this weekend?</i>
	Work glove — What kind of work do you do? <i>How did you get started?</i> What do you like about your work?
	Airplane — How much travel do you do? Where do you like to travel most? <i>What’s your favorite place in the world?</i>

The questions don’t go in a fixed order — pick one that fits and let the conversation wander.



Why question styles matter. We all default to closed questions out of habit. The whole game is making the switch to open ones — that's what turns a dead-end into a story.

Closed — avoid

Do you...? Can you...?

Have you...? Is it...?

Would you...? Did you...?

→ short, dead-end, one-word answers

Open — aim for

What...?

Tell me about...

Talk to me about...

Walk me through... · Paint me a picture... · Help me understand...

→ paragraphs, stories, real connection

Avoid

"Did you have a good weekend?"

Yes / no. Dead end.

Better

"How was your weekend?"

Open, but may get "good."

Ideal

"What's the best thing you did this weekend?"

Invites a real story.

The secret: to make someone like you, get them talking about themselves.



Initiate Discovery Double Clicks

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A good question gets someone talking. *Keeping it going* — and making them feel heard — comes from double clicks.

Take one or two words from what they just said and turn them into your next question.

You'll learn more, and they'll know you're really listening. It shows you're paying attention — and the conversation runs itself. They feel like they're leading. You are.

▶ Watch a word become the next question

"I'm going to my **sister's** graduation."

↳ **Where's she graduating from?**

↳ **What did she study?**

↳ **What's she going to do next?**

Each question is built from a word they just gave you.

Try it

- They say: "I had a busy *weekend* — we moved my daughter into her dorm." Write two double-click questions you could ask next.



The most powerful two-word follow-up there is. When someone trails off, they're usually being polite — not finished. Ask "And what else?" and about half the time they keep going — and that's where the real stuff comes out.

~150

words we **speak** per minute

~1,500

words we **think** per minute

So there's always more in there than they've said — "and what else?" gives them permission to find it.

Helpful lead-ins

"And what else?"

"Say more about that..."

"What else is on your mind about that?"

When they finally say "there's nothing else" — **congratulations.** You've learned all there is to know on that topic. Move on to the next one.



Conversation & Rapport Apply This Week

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Before next Friday, try each of these at least once.

- ☐ **Use the stack.** Run it in one real conversation — let it wander.
- ☐ **Double-click.** Take a word from their answer and ask about that.
- ☐ **Ask “and what else?”** When they trail off, give them room to keep going.

Bring to Session 2

Write two open-ended questions you could ask almost anyone:

Your challenge: “Stack” someone this week — a friend, a parent, a stranger — and see how much you can learn about them.

Next Friday, June 12 — The Business Stack: plus labeling, mirroring, restating, and listening to understand.